

Ben Crotteau

U.S. Campaigns and Elections

Professor Dolan

17 December 2024

Bacon is Back: How Republican Don Bacon Secured Re-Election in the Blue Dot

Don Bacon is a political enigma. Bacon, a Republican, won re-election in 2024 in Nebraska's 2nd Congressional District by a mere 1.8 points to secure a fifth term in the U.S. House of Representatives despite massive headwinds (NBC 2024). Bacon faced a candidate endorsed by the Nebraska GOP in the Republican primary, a lack of support from Donald Trump, a popular Democratic challenger that nearly unseated him in 2022, and a district likely to support Democratic presidential nominee Kamala Harris (Hoff 2024) (Sanderford 2022) (FiveThirtyEight 2024). Yet, Bacon emerged victorious by the skin of his teeth. The uphill climb is nothing new for Bacon, however. Bacon had to overcome incumbent advantage to unseat Democrat Brad Ashford in the 2016 election, the leftward swing of NE-02 in the 2020 presidential election, and Trump's call for a Republican challenger in 2022 (Ballotpedia) (Beck 2020) (Sanderford 2022). Furthermore, Bacon never won an election by more than 4.6 points with most of these wins coming with margins of 2 points or less (Ballotpedia). How does Bacon win time and time again? How has Bacon mitigated the success of both political parties and survived their criticism to remain a constant force in politics for the past eight years? I argue that incumbent Don Bacon won re-election in NE-02 because his campaign messaging positioned himself as a bipartisan, moderate Republican that stays in touch with the leanings of the district which resulted in securing sufficient split-ticket voters to overcome the Democratic victory at the presidential level.

Before diving into the reasons that Don Bacon won re-election in NE-02, I will provide a background to the race and an overview of the district. Don Bacon is a retired Air Force Brigadier General and current congressman representing NE-02 (Yohnka 2014) (Ballotpedia). His opponent, Democratic challenger Tony Vargas, is a current Nebraska State Senator, former Omaha school board member, and former Omaha Public Schools teacher (Nebraska Legislature). Bacon and Vargas faced off against each other in 2022 with Bacon winning by only 1.6 points despite polls projecting an easy victory

for the incumbent (Sanderford 2022). The fact that Vargas was relatively unknown in national politics in 2022 combined with the political landscape of NE-02 sparked hope among Democrats that they could flip this seat in 2024 (Grisales 2024).

The political landscape of NE-02 is characterized by moderateness. Geographically, NE-02 is on the eastern Nebraska border and contains all of Douglas County and Saunders County and parts of western Sarpy County (Nebraska Legislature 2023). Douglas County is the home to Omaha, the biggest city in Nebraska (Dalstrom 2024). Saunders County is rural (Nebraska Association of County Officials 2020). Sarpy County contains some of the suburbs of Omaha (Nebraska Association of County Officials 2020). The Cook Partisan Index rates NE-02 EVEN which means that it is neither more liberal or conservative than the United States as a whole (Cook Political Report 2023). Thus, relative to the country, NE-02 is a moderate district.

Additionally, NE-02 receives a substantial amount of national attention for a single congressional district as a result of Nebraska's electoral splitting system at the national level as well as the district's moderateness. In presidential elections, Nebraska awards two electoral votes to the statewide winner, and one electoral vote for each congressional district won by a candidate (Rembert 2024). This system positions congressional districts as their own entities to prioritize for candidates, and if the race is close in these districts they are targeted in the same manner swing states are (Rembert 2024). NE-01 and NE-03 are safe Republican districts, so national attention is not given to them (Cook Political Report 2023). In recent election cycles, NE-02 has been moderate, however, and has allocated its electoral vote three times to the Democratic presidential candidate and four times to the Republican presidential candidate since Nebraska began splitting their electoral votes in 2000 (Civic Nebraska 2024). The battleground nature of NE-02 has resulted in national attention for the district as both Republicans and Democrats believe that they can win on the presidential and congressional levels (Rembert 2024) (Civic Nebraska 2024).

It appeared that NE-02 was moving leftward in the years preceding the 2024 elections as a result of past presidential elections. NE-02 voted for Republican Mitt Romney in 2012 and Republican Donald Trump in 2016, but reversed this trend of voting Republican by voting for Democrat Joe Biden in 2020

(Civic Nebraska 2024). Congressional results told a different story, however. Don Bacon defeated incumbent Democrat Brad Ashford in 2016 and has held on to his seat regardless of which presidential candidate the district voted for in the election cycles since (Ballotpedia). Nevertheless, it is clear that NE-02 is a moderate district as it has voted for both Democrats and Republicans for president and the House in the past twenty years, and its national attention highlights that it is a swing district.

In response to the political landscape of NE-02, Don Bacon has effectively positioned himself as a moderate, bipartisan, and an efficacious politician. Bacon achieved this image through emphasizing certain aspects of his time in office thus far, avoiding issues he took a more extreme stance on, and distancing himself from Donald Trump. First, to position himself as a moderate, bipartisan lawmaker, Bacon highlighted economic legislation that he supported in Congress and recognition given to him from several non-partisan sources. Bacon was one of thirteen House Republicans to support the Bipartisan Infrastructure Bill that secured funding to improve infrastructure in NE-02. This included renovating Eppley Airfield in Omaha which is the primary airport for a majority of Nebraskans (DeFazio 2021) (U.S. Department of Transportation 2022). In addition to the economic benefits that NE-02 derived from this act, Bacon was able to use his support for a Democratic piece of legislation to push the narrative that he is a bipartisan lawmaker less interested in party loyalty than delivering results for his constituents. In NE-02, the economy is the most important issue for voters as a whole and Independents and Republicans specifically (SSRS 2024). By emphasizing an issue that was the most important for many voters in his district, Bacon was able to convey himself as an effective politician that prioritized his constituents' needs. Bacon incorporated the economic results he's brought to the district into his public image through campaign communications which I will explore in greater detail when analyzing Bacon's campaign strategy. Thus, Bacon was able to position himself as a moderate through his bipartisan support of a spending bill while at the same time highlighting his economic successes which is important to NE-02.

Additionally, Don Bacon highlighted recognition he received from several non-partisan congressional evaluators to build his moderate and bipartisan image. One Bacon video advertisement has text indicating he was rated the most bipartisan member of Congress by Common Ground Scorecard and

many others include the fact that he was rated the most effective Republican member in the 117th Congress by the Center for Effective Lawmaking (Bacon 2024) (Center for Effective Lawmaking 2023) (Sines 2024). Emphasizing the recognition that he has received from non-partisan sources conveys the moderate, bipartisan, and effective image that Bacon was striving for

Second, Don Bacon minimized the issue of abortion and reproductive rights; two topics where he trends more conservative than his district. Bacon supports, at a minimum, restricting access to abortion (Bacon 2022) (Israel 2024). Before Bacon took office, he responded to a 2016 candidate survey stating that he opposed legal abortion without exceptions for rape, incest, or protecting the life of the mother (Israel 2024). Bacon's stance before entering office was very extreme. In office, he voted against the Women's Health Protection Act of 2022 which prevents government restrictions at any level for abortion or other family planning methods. He also opposed the Ensuring Access to Abortion Act of 2022 which prevents states from prohibiting a person from receiving out-of-state abortion services (Bacon 2022). Bacon co-sponsored the Life at Conception Act several times in the House which abortion rights advocates claim is a total abortion ban (Knapp 2024). It is clear from Bacon's actions as a congressman that he is staunchly anti-abortion.

However, NE-02 is in favor of protecting access to abortion. Abortion is the third most important issue to Independent voters and voters regardless of party in NE-02 according to a 2024 poll (SSRS 2024). Additionally, the importance of abortion can be seen in analyzing the county-by-county results for Nebraska Ballot Initiative 439 which sought to institute a state constitutional amendment to protect abortion access until fetal viability. Ballot Initiative 439 received 59,000 more votes for than against in Douglas and Saunders counties combined (Evnen 2024). This figure exceeded the total number of votes against in Sarpy County which also had a majority in favor of the initiative (Evnen 2024). Thus, Ballot Initiative 439 passed easily in NE-02.

Bacon realized that his extreme stance on abortion left him vulnerable for attacks by Tony Vargas, and therefore took several steps to limit the fallout. First, Bacon removed the section on his campaign website dedicated to his pro-life stance and left it out of campaign advertisements (Stuart 2024). Speech is

powerful, and by not speaking about his pro-life opinions he aimed to disassociate himself from these views. Second, during public debates with Vargas when Bacon could not duck questioning of his pro-life position, he adopted a more moderate stance and attempted to undermine Vargas' credibility (Schammert 2024) (Knapp 2024). Bacon claimed that he was in support of Nebraska's current twelve week restriction on abortion despite his support of the Life at Conception Act signaling that he may be in favor of a total ban (Schammert 2024) (Knapp 2024). The twelve week restriction on abortion is certainly a more moderate view than a total ban without exception, even if it is still more extreme than the views held by his district. Bacon also called Vargas a liar in response to the latter's claim that the former was in support of total abortion bans without exceptions due to rape or incest (Bacon 2022). Again, words are powerful and throwing doubt on whether those claims are true minimizes the negative consequences from taking a more extreme stance on abortion than his district. Vargas' claim is true based on Bacon's own survey responses, and Bacon's acts in Congress certainly don't tell a different story, but Bacon's words threw doubt on the truth of that statement. Bacon recognized the importance of limiting the fallout from his extreme stance on abortion relative to his district, and took actions to distance himself from these views.

Third, Don Bacon effectively distanced himself from Donald Trump and far-right members of his own party who are not popular in the moderate NE-02. On several occasions, Bacon has drawn the ire of Trump and other members of the Republican Party. Bacon voted to pass the Bipartisan Infrastructure Bill, voted to certify the 2020 election results, and criticized Trump for mishandling classified documents (Sanderford 2022) (NBC News 2023). These actions angered Trump to the point where he called for a Republican challenger to Bacon in the Republican primary for the 2022 congressional elections and called Bacon "bad news" (Sanderford 2023). Trump's actions mobilized right-wing MAGA Republicans to challenge Bacon not just in 2022, but in 2024 as well (Sanderford 2022) (Sanderford 2024). Bacon did not receive the endorsement of the Nebraska GOP in the Republican primary (Sanderford 2024). After his 2024 primary victory, Bacon did not receive Trump's endorsement until September 17, less than two months ahead of the general election (Vargas 2024). It is clear that Bacon and Trump have a tense relationship which has negatively impacted Bacon's support from other right-wing members of the

Republican party. Bacon's refusal to bend to the will of Trump has resulted in attempts by his own party to have him ousted from his seat, and it is clear to politicians and voters alike that Bacon distanced himself from right-wing Republicans.

However, Donald Trump is not popular in NE-02, so Don Bacon's campaign was not damaged by the rift with Trump. Democrat Joe Biden received NE-02's electoral vote in the 2020 presidential election and Democrat Kamala Harris received it in 2024 (Civic Nebraska 2024). NE-02 did vote for Trump in 2016, indicating that at one point the voters in the district believed that Trump was the presidential candidate that best represent their values. The subsequent switch implies that voters in NE-02 district disagreed with Trump's vision for the Republican party and the United States as a whole after witnessing his first term in office. The success of Democrats at the presidential level was not seen at the congressional level, however, as Bacon retained his House seat showing that Trump is less popular than another Republican in NE-02 (Ballotpedia). Bacon's success in the wake of Trump's defeats in NE-02 in 2020 and 2024 shows both the relative unpopularity of Trump compared to other Republicans, and the relative popularity of Bacon compared to Trump.

Despite attempts from Republicans to oust Don Bacon from his congressional seat in primaries, Bacon has handily defeated the opposition. In 2022, Steve Kuehl challenged Bacon (Sanderford 2022). Kuehl ran on economic conservatism, and, like Trump, criticized Bacon's vote for the Bipartisan Infrastructure Bill alleging that the \$1.2 trillion in spending caused inflation (Sanderford 2022). Kuehl lost by 55 points (Ballotpedia). In 2024, Dan Frei, a Trump loyalist, challenged Bacon (Sanderford 2024). Frei, a former Tea Party member and Freedom Caucus supporter, secured the Nebraska GOP endorsement in the primary, and ran on his blind support for Trump (Sanderford 2024). Bacon beat Frei by 24 points (Ballotpedia). Despite Bacon's shaky support from the Republican establishment and tense relationship with Donald Trump, he easily secured victory in these primary elections. When presented with the choice, voters in NE-02 rejected Trump's right-wing populist vision for the Republican party and rewarded Bacon for the distance he established between himself and the movement (Crowley 2024). By establishing this

distance, Bacon portrayed himself as relatively moderate and bipartisan in comparison to other members of the GOP which NE-02 values in a candidate.

In addition to curating a moderate and bipartisan image, Don Bacon ran an effective campaign that was an important factor in his victory to win re-election. Bacon's campaign used focused communication and deployed a strong ground game. Campaign communication is important for a candidate to convey to voters a carefully thought-out image of themselves (Feltus et al 2019). Bacon's image as a moderate and bipartisan candidate would not have been effective without well-targeted communication (Feltus et al 2019). Bacon conveyed this image through advertisements that portrayed him as bipartisan, moderate, and effective. As I stated previously, several advertisements touted recognition Bacon received for his bipartisanship and effectiveness from non-partisan sources (Bacon 2024). Additionally, in these advertisements, Bacon honed in on specific issues that were important to NE-02 voters which included the economy, the most important issues to all voters, Independent voters, and Republican voters in NE-02 (Bacon 2024) (SSRS 2024). These advertisements emphasized Bacon's disapproval of President Biden's policies in causing inflation and highlighted the work that Bacon has done to bring back jobs and money for the district (Bacon 2024). Bacon also rolled out advertisements that criticized Vargas' economic policies in the Nebraska State Legislature (Bacon 2024). Collectively, these advertisements positioned Bacon as a candidate well-equipped to deal with economic issues by undermining unpopular Democratic economic policies and addressing the issue of inflation important to many voters (SSRS 2024). Bacon also focused on the topics of immigration and crime in his advertisements which are issues that appeal to Republicans (SSRS 2024). In these advertisements, Bacon adopted conventional conservative positions by linking immigration and crime, stating his desire to employ more border patrol agents and pledging complete support for police departments in their current form (Bacon 2024) (RNC 2024). While these positions were steadfastly conservative and not bipartisan, these advertisements appealed to Republicans in the hopes of maximizing party loyalty and turnout especially in the wake of his conflict with the Republican establishment.

Bacon employed a strong ground game as well, an important component of a campaign especially in a moderate swing district like NE-02. Bacon claimed to have knocked on over 160,000 doors during the election cycle (Bacon 2024). Assuming that each door knocked on was for one voter, Bacon reached out to roughly 38% of the district's eligible voters (Evnen 2020). However, from my experience as a political canvasser, a good percentage of the time knocking on one door reaches two or more eligible voters. Thus, the number of voters Bacon reached was likely in the ballpark of half of the eligible voters of the district. It was important for Bacon to have a large ground game because of the tight races and slim margins of victory that have characterized recent congressional elections in NE-02. In the 2024 election, Bacon won by a mere 6,000 votes which is a sliver of the 160,000 doors that Bacon's campaign knocked on (NBC 2024). Engaging undecided voters is important to any campaign, and it has been shown that direct interaction is more persuasive and effective than other forms of campaign communication especially if a canvasser can get a person to talk to them (Cherry 2020). Bacon's ground game allowed him to more personally convey his moderate and bipartisan image to the voters that in particular care about those two traits: undecided, Independent voters (Pew Research Center 2019). Thus, with the tight margins in the race as well as the sheer size of Bacon's ground game, it is clear that it gave his campaign momentum in persuading and communicating to voters the message that he wanted them to hear, giving him a boost in votes.

While Don Bacon's image as a candidate and his campaign strategy played a large role in his re-election, national and local trends during the 2024 election cycle were an important part of Bacon's victory as well. Nationally, Democrats' underperformance relative to 2020 and the general shift of the electorate to the right certainly aided Bacon (Bloch et al 2024). In the 2020 presidential election, Joe Biden defeated Donald Trump in NE-02 by 7 points and Bacon received 20,000 more votes than Trump (Politico 2020) (Ballotpedia). Kamala Harris was polling to match or exceed Biden's victory prior to the election (FiveThirtyEight). However, Harris won by only 4 points and Bacon received 12,000 more votes than Trump (NBC 2024). Bacon outperformed Trump in both elections, but required a significantly larger number of split ticket voters to win in 2020 than in 2024 as a result of Trump's better performance in the

district (Bloch et al 2024). As a down-ballot Republican, Bacon was able to ride the coattails of Trump's success while still receiving sufficient split-ticket voters to retain the seat (Political Dictionary 2021). The underperformance of Democrats certainly paved the way for Bacon to win re-election.

Locally, in 2024, Republicans made up a larger share of the electorate in NE-02 than in 2020 and 2022 (Evnen 2020). Beginning in 2023, Nebraska implemented a new map of congressional districts with lines redrawn based on the 2020 census (Nebraska Legislature 2023). Up until 2022, NE-02 contained all of blue Douglas County and most of Sarpy County, which contains the purple suburbs of Omaha (All About Redistricting 2022). In 2024, NE-02 still contained all of Douglas County, but it had a smaller portion of Sarpy County and replaced it with rural and red Saunders County (Nebraska Legislature 2023). As a result, the percentage share held by registered Democrats in the electorate in NE-02 dropped by 1.1 points between the 2022 and 2024 elections (Evnen 2020). The percentage share held by Republicans increased by 0.15 points (Evnen 2020). While these numbers seem insignificant, the race itself was decided by 1.8 points (NBC 2024). Therefore, NE-02 experienced a rightward shift in the electorate between 2022 and 2024 that significantly boosted Bacon's chances of winning given the tight margins of the race.

In conclusion, Don Bacon did it again. Through positioning himself as a bipartisan, moderate candidate, running an effective campaign, and taking advantage of national and local trends, Bacon survived yet another round of challenges and eked out another slim victory. I am interested to see how Bacon navigates the second Trump Administration given his tense history with the president-elect. The elections of 2026 are only two years away as well; there will undoubtedly be another showdown in NE-02. Assuming Bacon survives his challengers from within his own party and Vargas is prepared to go toe-to-toe with Bacon in a third consecutive election cycle, it will be another interesting and tight race.

Works Cited

- All About Redistricting. "Nebraska." *All about Redistricting*, 20 Jan. 2022, redistricting.ils.edu/state/nebraska/?cycle=2010&level=Congress&startdate=2011-05-26. Accessed 15 Dec. 2024.
- Bacon, Don. "We Knocked on over 160,000 Doors This Cycle. It's Our Secret Sauce for Victory since 2016." *X*, 5 Nov. 2024, x.com/donjbacon. Accessed 15 Dec. 2024.
- Bacon, Don. "Bacon Supports Life, Votes against Radical Federal Abortion Bills." *U.S. Congressman Don Bacon*, 15 July 2022, bacon.house.gov/news/documentsingle.aspx?DocumentID=1031.
- . "Don Bacon for Congress." *YouTube*, 2024, www.youtube.com/channel/UCh2eM8t0i-nU1IDHCJj5i3g. Accessed 15 Dec. 2024.
- Ballotpedia. "Don Bacon." *Ballotpedia*, ballotpedia.org/Don_Bacon.
- Beck, Margery. "Democrat Joe Biden Garners Rare Nebraska Electoral Vote." *AP News*, 4 Nov. 2020, apnews.com/article/election-2020-donald-trump-lincoln-omaha-elections-1139307c472f6c14599ed5761c247671. Accessed 15 Dec. 2024.
- Bloch, Matthew, et al. "Early Results Show a Red Shift across the U.S." *The New York Times*, 6 Nov. 2024, www.nytimes.com/interactive/2024/11/06/us/politics/presidential-election-2024-red-shift.html.
- Center for Effective Lawmaking. "Find Legislators." *Center for Effective Lawmaking*, 2023, thelawmakers.org/find-representatives.
- Cherry, Steven. "To Get Folks to Vote, Go Old School." *IEEE Spectrum*, 29 Oct. 2020, spectrum.ieee.org/voter-turnout. Accessed 16 Dec. 2024.
- Civic Nebraska. "Protect 2025: Nebraska's Split Electoral Vote Process." *Civic Nebraska*, 10 Dec. 2024, civicnebraska.org/20241210-protect-split-electoral-vote-process/. Accessed 15 Dec. 2024.
- Cook Political Report. "2023 Cook PVISM: District Map and List (118th Congress)." *Cook Political Report*, 5 Apr. 2023, www.cookpolitical.com/cook-pvi/2023-partisan-voting-index/118-district-map-and-list.
- Crowley, Stephen. "What Explains Trumpism?" *The Nation*, 25 Nov. 2024, www.thenation.com/article/politics/trump-populism-capitalism-nationalism/. Accessed 5 Dec. 2024.
- Dalstrom, Harl. "Omaha." *Encyclopedia Britannica*, 5 Dec. 2024, www.britannica.com/place/Omaha-city-Nebraska.
- DeFazio, Peter A. "Actions - H.R.3684 - 117th Congress (2021-2022): Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act." *Congress.gov*, 1 Oct. 2021, www.congress.gov/bill/117th-congress/house-bill/3684/actions.
- Evnen, Robert. "Nebraska Secretary of State - Election Night Results - November 5th, 2024." *Nebraska.gov*, 2024, electionresults.nebraska.gov/resultsSW.aspx?text=Race&type=PA&map=CTY. Accessed 14 Dec. 2024.
- . "Voter Registration Statistics." *Nebraska Secretary of State*, 27 Jan. 2020, sos.nebraska.gov/elections/voter-registration-statistics.
- Feltus, William, et al. *Producer and Stage Manager: Creating and Presenting the Campaigns Messages*. CQ Press, 2019.
- FiveThirtyEight. "Nebraska 2nd District: President: General Election : 2024 Polls." *FiveThirtyEight*, 13 Dec. 2024, projects.fivethirtyeight.com/polls/president-general/2024/nebraska/2/.
- Gonzalez Montero, Valeria. "Rep. Bacon: Trump Doesn't Have Moral Clarity on Putin's War." *CNN*, 18 Nov. 2024, www.cnn.com/2024/11/18/politics/video/the-lead-rep-don-bacon-nebraska-gop-democrats-ukraine-russia-military-missiles-jake-tapper. Accessed 14 Dec. 2024.
- Grisales, Claudia. "In Nebraska, Democrats' Push to Win the 'Blue Dot' Has GOP Congressman under Pressure." *NPR*, 16 Oct. 2024,

- www.npr.org/2024/10/15/nx-s1-5144673/nebraskas-blue-dot-a-thorn-for-gop-puts-republican-congressional-seat-in-jeopardy.
- Hoff, Maya Marchel. "Ahead of November Election, Nebraska's Don Bacon Must Fend off Tough Republican Challenge." *USA TODAY*, 13 May 2024, www.usatoday.com/story/news/politics/elections/2024/05/13/don-bacon-nebraska-second-district-republican-primary/73426689007/. Accessed 14 Dec. 2024.
- Israel, Josh. "Rep. Don Bacon's Record on Abortion, Guns and the Economy Contradicts Claims of Centrism." *The Nebraska Independent*, 27 June 2024, nebraskaindependentnews.com/Politics/don-bacon-2024-house-representatives-election-tony-vargas-abortion-guns-economy. Accessed 14 Dec. 2024.
- Knapp, Fred. "Fact Check: A Look into Statements Made by Congressional Candidates Bacon and Vargas during Debate." *Nebraska Public Media*, 11 Oct. 2024, nebraskapublicmedia.org/en/news/news-articles/fact-check-a-look-into-statements-made-by-congressional-candidates-bacon-and-vargas-during-debate/. Accessed 14 Dec. 2024.
- NBC. "Nebraska House District 2 Election 2024 Live Results." *NBC News*, 5 Nov. 2024, www.nbcnews.com/politics/2024-elections/nebraska-us-house-district-2-results.
- NBC News. "Bacon on Trump: Sharing Classified Iran Documents Is a Crime." *NBC News*, 25 June 2023, www.nbcnews.com/meet-the-press/video/bacon-on-trump-sharing-classified-iran-documents-is-a-crime-184834629530. Accessed 15 Dec. 2024.
- Nebraska Association of County Officials. "Sarpy County." *Nebraska Counties Explorer*, 2020, nebraskacounties.org/nebraska-counties/county/sarpy.html. Accessed 15 Dec. 2024.
- . "Saunders County." *Nebraska Counties Explorer*, 2020, nebraskacounties.org/nebraska-counties/county/saunders.html. Accessed 15 Dec. 2024.
- Nebraska Legislature. "Congress Maps Clearinghouse." *Nebraska Legislature*, 2023, nebraskalegislature.gov/about/congress_map.php.
- . "Nebraska Legislature." *Nebraska Legislature*, 2024, nebraskalegislature.gov/senators/landing-pages/index.php?District=7.
- Pew Research Center. "Political Independents: Who They Are, What They Think." *Pew Research Center - U.S. Politics & Policy*, 14 Mar. 2019, www.pewresearch.org/politics/2019/03/14/political-independents-who-they-are-what-they-think/.
- Political Dictionary. "Coattail Effect." *Political Dictionary*, 17 Sept. 2021, politicaldictionary.com/words/coattail-effect/.
- Politico. "Live Election Results: 2020 Nebraska Results." *Politico*, 2020, www.politico.com/2020-election/results/nebraska/.
- Rembert, Elizabeth. "Nebraska and Maine Split Their Electoral Vote. Is It a Better System than Winner-Take-All?" *Nebraska Public Media*, 3 Apr. 2024, nebraskapublicmedia.org/es/news/news-articles/nebraska-and-maine-split-their-electoral-vote-is-it-a-better-system-than-winner-take-all/.
- RNC. "The 2024 Republican Platform." 2024.
- Sanderford, Aaron. "Bacon Loses Lone GOP Primary Challenger, Gains Another in Omaha-Area House Race." *Nebraska Examiner*, 28 Feb. 2022, nebraskaexaminer.com/2022/02/28/bacon-loses-lone-gop-primary-challenger-gains-another-in-omaha-area-house-race/. Accessed 14 Dec. 2024.
- . "Bacon Tops Vargas, Brings Home 2nd District U.S. House Win for Fourth Time." *Nebraska Examiner*, 9 Nov. 2022, nebraskaexaminer.com/2022/11/09/bacon-beats-vargas-to-bring-home-2nd-district-u-s-house-win-for-fourth-time/. Accessed 15 Dec. 2024.
- . "Bacon, Already Attacked by Trump, Now under Fire from Lincoln Project." *Nebraska Examiner*, 8 Feb. 2023,

- nebraskaexaminer.com/2023/02/07/bacon-already-attacked-by-trump-now-under-fire-from-lincoln-project/.
- . "Dan Frei Says He Will Pursue Freedom Caucus Label in GOP Primary Bid against Rep. Don Bacon." *Nebraska Examiner*, 27 Jan. 2024, nebraskaexaminer.com/2024/01/27/dan-frei-says-he-will-pursue-freedom-caucus-label-in-gop-primary-bid-against-rep-don-bacon/. Accessed 14 Dec. 2024.
- . "Pillen Snatches Victory from Trump Pick Herbster in Nebraska's GOP Gubernatorial Primary." *Nebraska Examiner*, 11 May 2022, nebraskaexaminer.com/2022/05/10/pillen-snatches-victory-from-trump-pick-herbster-in-nebraska-s-gop-gubernatorial-primary/. Accessed 14 Dec. 2024.
- . "U.S. Rep. Don Bacon Keeps Outperforming the "Blue Dot" in Nebraska's 2nd District." *Nebraska Examiner*, 25 Nov. 2024, nebraskaexaminer.com/2024/11/25/u-s-rep-don-bacon-keeps-outperforming-the-blue-dot-in-nebras-2nd-district/.
- Schammert, Bill. "Get the Facts: Fact Checking Bacon Ad Using KETV Fact Check." *KETV*, 24 Oct. 2024, www.ketv.com/article/get-the-facts-fact-checking-bacon-ad-using-ketv-fact-check/62709335. Accessed 14 Dec. 2024.
- Sines, Justin. "Scorecard Updates Rankings of Politicians' Success Seeking Common Ground on Issues That Matter to Voters." *Common Ground Committee*, 10 June 2024, commongroundcommittee.org/scorecard-updates-rankings-of-politicians-success-seeking-common-ground-on-issues-that-matter-to-voters-2/. Accessed 14 Dec. 2024.
- SSRS. "Two-State Poll North Carolina and Nebraska 2nd CD." 27 Sept. 2024.
- Stuart, Tessa. "Endangered Republican Don Bacon Quietly Deletes Anti-Abortion Endorsements from Website." *Rolling Stone*, 22 Mar. 2024, www.rollingstone.com/politics/politics-features/don-bacon-deletes-anti-abortion-endorsements-1234991819/.
- U.S. Department of Transportation. "The Bipartisan Infrastructure Law Will Deliver for Nebraska." *U.S. Department of Transportation*, 2022, www.transportation.gov/sites/dot.gov/files/2022-01/BIL_Nebraska.pdf.
- Vargas, Tony. "Tony Vargas Statement on Don Bacon's Acceptance of Trump's Endorsement." *Tony Vargas for Congress*, 18 Sept. 2024, www.vargasfornebraska.com/news/tony-vargas-statement-on-don-bacons-acceptance-of-trumps-endorsement. Accessed 15 Dec. 2024.
- Yohnka, Dennis. "Gen. Bacon Set to Retire." *The Daily Journal*, 12 July 2014, www.daily-journal.com/news/local/gen-bacon-set-to-retire/article_a1f0bc3d-c6ec-5e1b-8424-cd0ba43d6b91.html. Accessed 15 Dec. 2024.